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The role of involvement and attachment in satisfaction with local government services

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to report on the development and testing of involvement and attachment constructs, which are then used to investigate the effects of involvement and attachment on perceptions of satisfaction with services delivered to residents by a local government body.

Design/methodology/approach – Data collected by means of a questionnaire-based survey of residents' satisfaction with local government services were used to test involvement and attachment constructs for validity and reliability. The relationship between these two constructs and satisfaction was then evaluated.

Findings – The findings in this paper indicated that the levels of involvement and attachment felt by residents did have both a direct and a combinatorial effect on perceptions of satisfaction with local government services. The larger attachment influence was positively associated with satisfaction, while involvement showed a weak negative association with satisfaction. A significant interaction effect also existed.

Research limitations/implications – The paper shows that, on average, residents with greater levels of attachment were more satisfied with local government service provision but those with more involvement were less satisfied.

Practical implications – The paper shows that, when they aim to improve perceptions of satisfaction with their service delivery, local government service providers need to address involvement and attachment effects.

Originality/value – The paper has developed valid and reliable constructs that can be used to measure the effect of residents' levels of community involvement and attachment on their satisfaction with local government service provision. It has also identified an unexpected negative association between involvement and satisfaction. The newly developed constructs provide psychometrically sound measures for use in local government research.

Keywords Local government, Research

Paper type Research paper

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Introduction

The sense of association that is felt by people towards a community, with which they are involved, has been the subject of research by a number of different writers under a range of headings such as community orientation, community satisfaction, and community attachment. For example, in the case of medical schemes, writers such as Proenca *et al.* (2000)and Barrows (1998) have examined community orientation programs and the links that they have established to the community.

Recent research by Allen and Filkens (2005) has highlighted the importance that social ties play in predicting community satisfaction and attachment. It has also been suggested that subjective measures of performance should be included in measures of community satisfaction and quality of life (Bardo and Dolmeci, 1990; Hughey and Bardo, 1987). Attachment and involvement can potentially be considered subjective

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measures. Further, active participation in a community has been found to be a key dimension of organisational commitment and satisfaction.

A number of writers have examined government service delivery and its relationship to satisfaction. Glaser and Hildreth (1999) explored the relationship between satisfaction and willingness to pay taxes and highlighted opportunities for strengthening the connection between performance and willingness to pay. However, there has been some criticism of the instruments used to measure satisfaction. For example, Van Ryzin (2004) has stated that little empirical research has been devoted to developing and testing measures of citizen satisfaction while Stipak (1979) suggested that care should be taken when conducting citizen satisfaction surveys. In order to overcome this potential problem, this research has used a single global measure of perceived satisfaction, which does not allow for the introduction of any possible errors of interpretation or confusion because of inappropriately introduced components in a multivariate satisfaction measure.

Other researchers have developed models to integrate factors leading to satisfaction, with Serra (1995), utilising a probit modelling approach. Van Ryzin *et al.* (2004), in turn, applied an adapted version of the American Customer Satisfaction Index (Fornell *et al.*, 1996) structural equations based model to examine the relationship between satisfaction measures, quality and two outcome variables of "move out" and "trust government". However, no research has been found that has examined the effects of community involvement and attachment on perceptions of satisfaction with local government service delivery. Hence, the purpose of this paper is to report on the results of research undertaken to explore the effects of such community involvement and attachment.

Community satisfaction

Community satisfaction has been examined in relation to a range of effects such as migration intentions (Vogt *et al.*, 2001) and it has been the subject of numerous surveys by town and city councils in Australia (for example Lismore City Council, Port Philip Council, Hornsby Shire and Gladstone). It has also been surveyed by medical and police services (see, for example, Nyhan and Martin (1999), Proenca *et al.* (2000), Kuisma *et al.* (2003) and Hulka *et al.* (1975).

A number of researchers have examined the factors that affect community satisfaction. For example Campbell *et al.* (1976) identified nine community attributes affecting levels of community satisfaction while Bardo and Dolmeci (1990) and Hughey and Bardo (1987) identified four factors comprising community satisfaction; friendliness, care by the community, belongingness, quality of community life and alienation/acceptance.

Social dimensions were considered by Goudy (1977) who identified primary group relationships, community participation, commitment, viability, heterogeneity, power distribution and community pride as affecting varying levels of community attachment, community as a place to live and evaluation of the community. Social dimensions were found to have a greater effect on community evaluations than evaluations of government services. Filkins *et al.* (2000) provided support for the findings of both Goudy (1977) and Brown (1993), that both social dimensions and satisfaction with employment are important predictors of community satisfaction. Filkins *et al.* (2000) also found that some services such as local government, consumer

services and education are more important than others that were examined including environmental services and basic medical care. Puddifoot (1995) has also found social dimensions in the form of family ties and the length of time people had lived in an area were important in the way they identified with a local town. These findings support the notion that it is more than the delivery of physical services that influence people's level of satisfaction with the place where they live.

Community attachment

A large body of research literature has been associated with the examination of community attachment, which has been researched by writers such as Buttel *et al.* (1979), Um and Crompton (1987), McCool and Martin (1994), Williams *et al.* (1995), Ritzer (1996) Jurowski (1998). In these studies, the relationship between community attachment and some perceived consequential effects such as social and economic effects and tourism development have been explored.

Much of the research into community attachment has been carried out in sociological studies. These have focussed on the determination of the presence or absence of such a community feeling and the drivers of the feelings such as geographical location, educational experience, friendliness within the community, length of residency, etc.

In attachment studies, attachment has often been measured by the length of time that the respondents have spent in a particular area or region. However, the use of length of time in an area as a measure of attachment, can be questioned and there is no evidence to indicate what length of time is to be considered to reflect feelings of attachment or whether all persons who have spent a long time in an area will experience feelings of attachment. For this reason, in this study, in order to obtain a better measure of the attachment feelings of the respondents, a four-item measure of attachment was designed, tested for validity and reliability and utilised in a final latent variable model and in an analysis of variance.

Community involvement

Community involvement is the level of activity an individual contributes to their local community. It plays an important part in our communities. Being involved in a voluntary activity indicates a level of pride in, and commitment to, the community. In addition, a large number of people are involved in community activities in any society. Such involvement can range from helping at the local school canteen or sports club through to formal involvement such as participation in local government. However, in the study of community satisfaction, the effect of community involvement has not been explored to any major extent.

A person living in a community has a social responsibility to contribute to that society and one way is through community activities. People who are involved with their community can be expected to feel better about them and to be more committed to the community.

An aspect of this research, which is based on a survey of a local community, is therefore to investigate whether a person's level of community involvement influences their perceptions of satisfaction with local government services. In addition, since attachment to a community can also be expected to influence a person's perceptions of satisfaction with local government services, the influence of attachment on satisfaction

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will be concurrently explored. It is hypothesised that members of a community who feel a strong sense of community linkage or involvement, will feel more satisfied with the overall nature of the service delivery by their local government and that a similar enhancement of perceived satisfaction will also occur in the case of persons who exhibit more attachment to their community.

The sample

Data were obtained from part of a survey that was carried out on behalf of a local government body, namely a city council. The survey was repeated and improved over a number of years. The data used in this research was obtained from the latest 2005 survey, which included a section aimed at assessing involvement and attachment. The data was collected by means of a single stage sampling of residents in the area of jurisdiction of an Australian Northern New South Wales City Council. The total population of the area was just over 43,000. A total of 3,000 questionnaires were mailed to residents, and after taking into account returns and blank responses, 501 useable responses were obtained for an effective response rate of 16.7 per cent. The sampling frame that was used was the council list of all ratepayers in its area of jurisdiction and the sample obtained was based on a random selection of households. Control was maintained for rural and urban residents based on the breakdown of urban/rural rateable properties in the local government area.

The instructions that were provided, maintained the only control over who responded, with the person next in line for a birthday being asked to complete the survey. It would appear from the results that this method resulted in the number of female respondents being slightly higher than the number of male respondents. There was also a skew toward older respondents, particularly among the males. The sample did however provide reasonable coverage of male and female proportions across all the age groups. The sample was stratified according to the geographic distribution of the population and was made up of 70 per cent urban and 30 per cent rural residents.

The survey questionnaire collected information from respondents on their overall level of satisfaction with the council delivery of services as well as their satisfaction with various aspects of service delivery provided by the council. Opinions regarding a number of statements about residents' attitudes towards their community as well as demographic information were also collected.

Because of the skew towards older residents, a check was made for any significant age-based differences in questionnaire responses in the sample achieved and those that would have been expected from a sample with an age distribution equal to that of the population. A sub-sample of the survey sample based on the age proportions in the population was developed by means of a random selection process. The sub-sample size was 133. A comparison was then made between the results obtained for the actual survey and those produced by the artificially created sample with age characteristics identical to those of the population. This comparison was carried out on each of six sectoral satisfaction questions. Mean response scores for the two samples were compared using a *z*-test for differences. No differences were significant at the 95 per cent confidence level, thus providing confidence that the results were representative of the population of the local government area, in spite of the age related difference in representation in the data (see Table I).

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Involvement scale development

A review of the literature identified involvement as having been examined in organizational behaviour (see Ward and Davis (1995) for a review). However, in order to measure involvement, in a local government context, an instrument needed to be developed. A review of the literature had not identified a scale that could be used for the intended purpose, since the items that were mentioned did not relate to the areas of involvement likely to be experienced by clients of a local government service provider. For this study, items were therefore devised based on qualitative research through in-depth interviews with community members with the resultant questionnaire being reviewed by four academic staff.

Involvement in the community is often referred to as being "community minded" so the in-depth interviews were used to identify elements that were indicative of a person being community minded. The responses together with types of items that were suggested by the literature were used as the basis for the items that were included in the survey instrument. Results from the interviews identified community involvement as being reflected by either participation, or a wish to participate in community committees such as schools, clubs or community groups. In addition, being involved in neighbourhood activities and a willingness to help others in the community were also identified as being measures of involvement.

The review of the literature and the in-depth discussions resulted in the identification of six items that provided a community involvement construct with acceptable face validity. These items are listed in Table II.

The six identified items were converted to statements to be scored on a five-point Likert type scale.

Attachment scale development

The items comprising the attachment scale were also developed from in-depth interviews that identified elements that constituted a person demonstrating

	Survey sample $n = 501$	Population based sample $n = 133$	z-values
Council leadership	3.37	3.46	0.81
Infrastructure and core services	3.36	3.39	0.32
Supporting quality of life	3.57	3.59	0.24
Environmental initiatives	3.61	3.61	0.00
Economic development activities	3.53	3.55	0.21
Overall satisfaction with council	3.55	3.59	0.39

Table I.
Comparison of mean values with those from samples drawn with distributions as per the survey and as per the population

(A)	I am involved in neighbourhood activities
(B)	It is important for me to be involved in community-based activities
(C)	I am very keen to hold official positions on community committees (e.g. schools, clubs, etc.)
(D)	I am community-minded
(E)	I am willing to spend time helping others and the community
(F)	I spend a lot of time involved in community activities

Table II.
Items identified as being associated with community involvement

attachment to their community. The four items that were identified as measuring attachment were related to feeling ownership of the city challenges, being happy to stay in the city forever, a feeling of belongingness and a feeling of personal connection with the local area. These four identified items were converted to statements to be scored on a five-point Likert type scale and the items are shown in Table III.

Satisfaction

In accordance with the practice that has been followed in a number of satisfaction studies, overall satisfaction was measured by means of a single item scored on a five-point numerical scale with anchor points of 1 = very dissatisfied to 5 = very satisfied (for examples of studies that have used a single item satisfaction measure, see Danaher and Mattsson, 1994; Yukseland and Rimmington, 1998; Leisen and Vance, 2001; Theodorakis *et al.*, 2001).

The satisfaction measure that was used, read as follows: Overall, taking into account all you know about XYZ Council, how satisfied are you with the performance of the Council?

Data analysis

The survey data was used to examine the involvement and attachment constructs by firstly evaluating their convergent validity using the EQS program to conduct a confirmatory factor analysis. The results of the tests of fit of the involvement construct are shown in Table IV.

Table III.
Items identified as being associated with community attachment

(G)	I would be very happy to spend the rest of my life in the XYZ area
(H)	I really feel as if XYZ area's challenges are my own
(I)	The XYZ area has a great deal of personal meaning for me
(J)	I feel very much that I belong in the XYZ area

Table IV.
Involvement construct fit indices

Chi-square	52.5
Pr > Chi-square	< 0.0001
Adjusted Goodness of Fit Index (GFI)	0.92
Comparative Fit Index	0.96
Standardised Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR)	0.04
Bentler and Bonett's Non-normed Index	0.93
Bentler and Bonett's Normed Fit Index	0.95
Bollen Incremental Fit Index	0.96
Variance extracted	0.50
Cronbach α	0.86
Standardised involvement construct indicator loadings	
(A) I am involved in neighbourhood activities	0.82
(B) It is important for me to be involved in community-based activities	0.85
(C) I am very keen to hold official positions on community committees	0.57
(D) I am community-minded	0.65
(E) I am willing to spend time helping others and the community	0.63
(F) I spend a lot of time involved in community activities	0.69

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The construct displayed an acceptable fit with all fit indices being greater than 0.9 and the standardised root mean square residual (SRMR) being below 0.05. All indicator loadings were significantly different from zero and their standardised values were greater than 0.5. The variance extracted was 0.50, which according to Hair *et al.* (2006), p. 777) represents an adequate level for acceptance of construct convergence validity.

Reliability was assessed using Cronbach α, which value was found to be 0.86. This was greater than the value of 0.8 in respect of which, Nunnally (1978) stated, "... increasing reliabilities much beyond 0.8 is often wasteful of time and funds. At that level correlations are attenuated very little by measurement error".

The attachment construct also displayed an acceptable fit with all fit indices being greater than 0.9 and the SRMR being below 0.05. All indicator loadings were significantly different from zero and their standardised values were greater than 0.5. The variance extracted was acceptable at a value of 0.57. Reliability was assessed using Cronbach α and was found to be 0.84.

The results of the tests of fit of the attachment construct are shown in Table V.

In order to assess the discriminant validity of the two constructs measuring attachment and involvement, the correlation between the constructs was determined. The squared correlation value of 0.12 was considerably smaller than the variance extracted values for either of the two constructs, indicating a satisfactory level of discriminant validity for both constructs (Hair *et al.* 2006, p. 778.)

The two constructs were now used in a latent variable model where the relationship between involvement, attachment and satisfaction was assessed. Because it was to be expected that some respondents would exhibit a relationship between their involvement and attachment orientations, this relationship was also included in the model in the form of a covariance between the involvement and the attachment constructs.

The model was found to provide an acceptable fit to the data and the results of the fit tests are shown in Table VI.

The model paths were all significantly different from zero at the 95 per cent level except for the path from involvement to satisfaction, which was significant at the 94 per cent level. The model and its standardised path values are shown in Figure 1.

Chi-square	25.5
Pr > Chi-square	< 0.0001
Adjusted Goodness of Fit Index (GFI)	0.89
Comparative Fit Index	0.97
Standardised Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR)	0.03
Bentler and Bonett's Non-normed Index	0.91
Bentler and Bonett's Normed Fit Index	0.97
Bollen Incremental Fit Index	0.97
Variance extracted	0.57
Cronbach α	0.84
Standardised attachment construct indicator loadings	
(G) I would be very happy to spend the rest of my life in the XYZ area	0.75
(H) I really feel as if XYZ area's challenges are my own	0.70
(I) The XYZ area has a great deal of personal meaning for me	0.78
(J) I feel very much that I belong in the XYZ area	0.78

Table V.
Attachment construct fit indices

To further explore the extent to which respondents evidenced greater levels of involvement with and attachment to their community, the involvement and attachment constructs were converted into single scores on a 1 to 5 scale by averaging the item scores for each construct after these had been weighted by the relevant factor loadings. Scores of greater than the scale value of 3.5 were classified as "more" and those of less than 2.5 were classified as "less", while scores of between 2.5 and 3.5 were classified as "neutral". The percentage of responses in these categories was then determined and the percentages are shown in Table VII.

Table VI.
Involvement, attachment and satisfaction model fit indices

Chi-square	127.1
Pr > Chi-square	<0.0001
Adjusted Goodness of Fit Index (GFI)	0.92
Comparative Fit Index	0.95
Standardised Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR)	0.045
Bentler and Bonett's Non-normed Index	0.93
Bentler and Bonett's Normed Fit Index	0.93
Bollen Incremental Fit Index	0.95

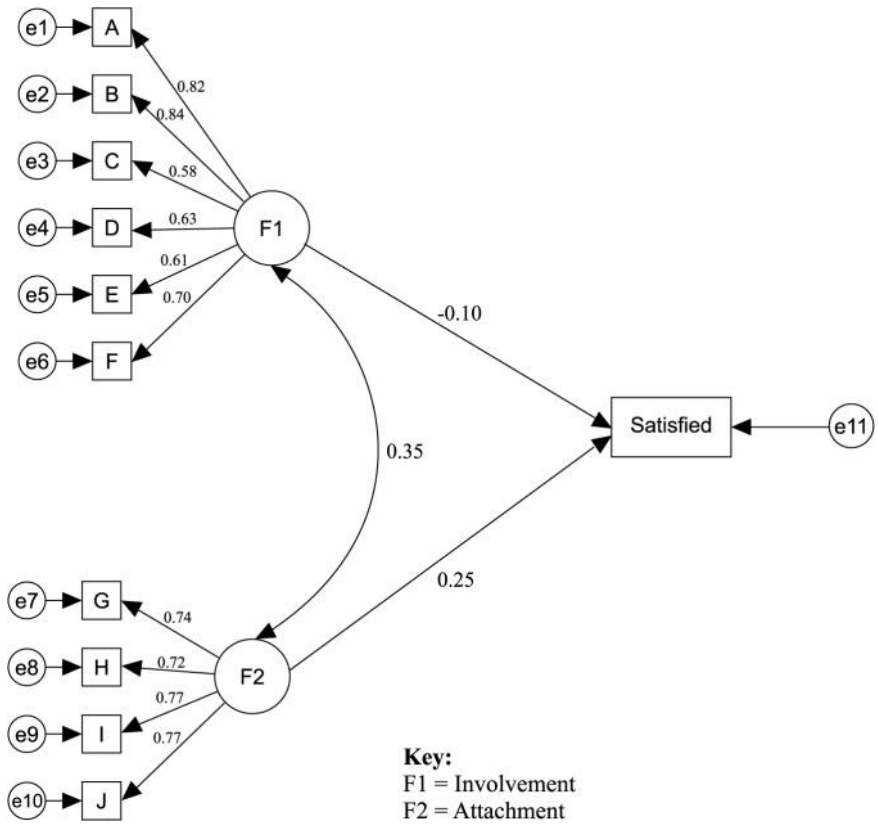


Figure 1.
Model of involvement, attachment and satisfaction

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It can be seen from this table, that 51.3 and 35.9 percent of attachment and involvement oriented persons registered in their respective "more" categories. The much lower level of involvement oriented in comparison to attachment-oriented persons suggests that the council should address the issue as to how to increase the level of involvement of persons in their community. However, they should also take cognizance of the fact that the persons recording higher involvement scores were less satisfied with performance (possibly, because they were more critical or because they were closer to the actual workings of the council) and that improving this aspect would need to be concurrently addressed.

An analysis of variance indicated that there were significant differences between the mean satisfaction scores for the "more" and "less" involvement and attachment groups with the mean score for people with more involvement being 3.23 and 3.35 for those with less involvement ($F = 3.39, p = 0.035$). In the case of attachment, the mean score for people with more attachment was 3.74 and it was 3.14 for those with less attachment ($F = 7.69, p = 0.001$). The analysis of variance made it possible to investigate the combined effect of involvement and attachment on the level of satisfaction of respondents. This interaction effect between attachment and involvement was significant ($F = 3.52, p = 0.008$) and indicated that there was some degree of increase or decrease in mean scores that resulted from the combination of both effects. The influence of the interaction effects are shown in Figure 2 and the overall mean scores are shown in Table VIII. Although the overall mean scores include both the interaction effects and the main effects of involvement and attachment, these mean scores provide a picture of the resultant overall outcome in terms of respondent

Table VII. Proportions of respondents with "more" and "less" levels of involvement and attachment

	Attachment	Involvement
More	51.3	35.9
Neutral	37.1	54.5
Less	11.6	9.6

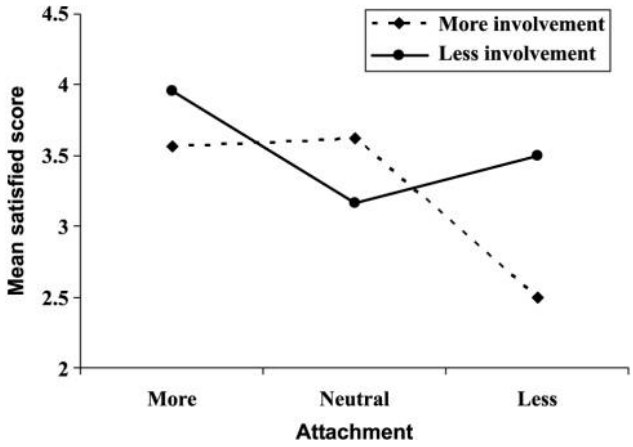


Figure 2. A graphical representation of main and interaction effects

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ratings on the satisfied scale. It is evident that the combination of low attachment and high involvement levels resulted in a reduction in the mean satisfied score, while the combination of high attachment and low involvement produced the highest mean satisfied score.

Conclusions

The results of this research indicated that at the 94 per cent certainty level, the level of involvement felt by residents of a city had a small negative influence (− 0.10) on their perceptions of satisfaction with their local government service provision. A hypothesis that members of a community, who feel a strong sense of community linkage or involvement, will also feel more satisfied with the overall nature of the service delivery by their local government was therefore rejected. However, the hypothesis that members of a community, who feel a strong sense of attachment to the community, will be more satisfied with the service delivery of their local government was supported since there was a significant positive relationship between attachment and satisfaction (0.25) at the 95 per cent level. This indicated that, on average, respondents who felt a strong sense of attachment to the city had rated the council's performance as being more satisfactory than those respondents who exhibited lesser feelings of attachment.

Fewer residents evidenced a "most" level of involvement than exhibited a "most" level of attachment, so that it was evident that some residents felt attachment to but were not involved with the community. However, the interaction effects indicated that some respondents evidenced both involvement and attachment.

The fact that involvement yielded a negative association could suggest that those people with more involvement had some contact with the council and were reflecting feelings of unhappiness with actions by the council or with the level of council action associated with their involvement.

Residents with greater feelings of attachment and involvement are likely to be more responsive to requests for suggestions and could be more inclined to provide comments about the performance of their local government body. The results therefore also suggest that local government bodies need particularly to communicate with and to take into account the comments that are received from those residents who evidence more attachment and more involvement.

The positive effect of attachment was more than twice as large as the negative effect of involvement. The significant analysis of variance interaction effect also indicated that some respondents exhibited both attachment and involvement. Because of the interaction effect, the mean satisfied score of the respondents was reduced to below the scale midpoint when involvement was high and attachment was low and the highest mean satisfied score for the respondents was found when involvement was low and attachment was high.

Table VIII.
Mean satisfied scores reflecting both interaction and main analysis of variance effects

	Attachment	Mean satisfied score
More involvement	More	3.56
	Neutral	3.62
	Less	2.50
Less involvement	More	3.96
	Neutral	3.17
	Less	3.50

An important aim of local government bodies should be to identify and to remove the negative effect that can exist with those persons who have feelings of involvement.

Further research is therefore required into the factors that affect the level of community involvement and attachment. The results of such research should then help to identify strategies that a local government body can use to gain a full benefit from these effects. For example, if a local government authority were to be more responsive to the members of their community who evidenced greater levels of involvement, they might gain a stronger level of appreciation of their efforts and possibly reverse or neutralise the negative influence of involvement on their residents' overall level of satisfaction with their performance.

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